

UFO CHRONICLE

by J. Antonio Huneus



Astronaut Gordon Cooper speaks up about UFOs

After a 14-year silence, legendary Mercury Seven astronaut Gordon Cooper is again talking about UFOs, things he saw, evidence he collected or transmitted, and his views about alien civilizations visiting Earth.

Cooper is an American hero and his credibility is beyond doubt. He granted at least two interviews with people working on UFO documentaries in the past year. I received the videotape of one of the interviews from Michael Hesemann, the well-known German ufologist, author, and documentarian from Düsseldorf.

Hesemann explained in an interview that he interviewed Cooper at his office in California on December 14, 1993. "I told him I wanted to interview him for a German TV program and video documentary," said Hesemann. "I started with general conversation about his space flights, then asked him about his UN initiative." Cooper's last public comments about UFOs were made in the late '70s during an effort to establish some kind of UFO "agency or department" at the United Nations led by the Prime Minister of Grenada, Sir Eric Gairy. Cooper supported this initiative with a now-famous letter dated November 9, 1978, to Ambassador Griffith of Grenada.

Cooper disclosed that, "I did have occasion in 1951 to have two days of observation of many flights of them, of different sizes, flying in fighter formation...over Europe." This happened in the early days of Cooper's military career when he was stationed at the Neubiberg Air Force Base in Munich. This

was of interest to Hesemann's German audience, so the first segment in the edited videotape is about Cooper's UFO sighting. The interview was released in German in Hesemann's latest video, *UFOs: The Secret Evidence*, as well as in his beautifully illustrated, 520-page book *Geheimsache U.F.O.* A partial transcript of the interview is published here in English for the first time, with Hesemann's kind permission.

"Well, we saw," begins Cooper, "the weathermen in our base saw—this was in Germany—saw these, looked like aircraft, very high altitude, flying over in formation very much like we fly in fighter outfits, and he [weatherman] was tracking weather balloons with binoculars and saw them and looked like quite good altitude and pretty soon several other people on the base had binoculars and were looking at them, but we could never even get airborne in our airplanes, we could never get close to them. They were well above where we were, but they were very metallic looking and double lenticular shape, flying in formations and going primarily from east to westerly direction, and we never could determine what they really were or were not."

Edwards landing film

In 1956 Cooper trained as an experimental test pilot at Edwards AFB in California. While there he applied for the then ultimate adventure in flying: NASA's Mercury program. He became one of seven astronauts selected, joining the program in January 1959. Before that, however, in May 1957, Cooper became involved in an extraordinary UFO incident at Edwards. A metallic-looking

craft with tripod gear landed and then took off right in front of an official film crew. The whole episode was filmed and sent to Washington in a special plane. This is what Cooper told Michael Hesemann on camera:

"Yes, I had a crew that was filming an installation of a precision landing system we were installing out on the dry lake bed, and they were there with stills and movies and filmed the whole installation and they came running in to tell me that this UFO, a little saucer, had come down right over them, put down three gear and landed about 50 yards from them, and as they proceeded to go on over to get a closer shot of it, it lifted up, put the gear in, and disappeared in a rapid rate of speed; and so I had to follow my directions as a military. I had to look up the regulations on who I was to call to report this, which I did, and they ordered me to immediately have the film developed, put it in a pouch, and send them by the Commanding General's plane to Washington, which I did, and that was the last I've ever heard of the film." Here we have an unimpeachable source stating that he saw with his own eyes an official film of a UFO landing and take-off at an air force base and that he reported the incident to his superiors.

The third section of Hesemann's interview offers a glimpse of Cooper's feelings about the nature of UFOs and why there doesn't seem to be any open contact: "I think they are a more advanced civilization; and they are traveling to here for whatever reason I don't know. Yes, I think this is one impression that every astronaut who has flown in space has come home feeling the fact that it's a

shame we can't learn to live in peace, because you don't see any boundaries up there from space, and I am wondering if maybe that isn't the same impression that any extraterrestrial vehicles coming to Earth might feel. If we can't learn to live in peace then maybe they shouldn't even associate with us."

More revelations

Gordon Cooper granted a second interview to a film crew directed by Sam Sherman of the Independent-International Pictures Corp. Sherman is producing a film titled *Beyond This Earth*, to be released in the fall. In a recent interview, Sherman told us that the film "is made for theaters and TV" and that it combines documentary segments and footage with "dramatic contents; it will have some actors and celebrities for dramatic segments with our own conclusions." Although I haven't yet seen this material, Sam Sherman confirmed that "we did interview Gordon Cooper, who did say some strange things... He was reticent to talk at first, he seemed to know a lot about the subject. Basically, he indicated he was under some kind of oath."

Sherman added that Cooper "said he had worked on a UFO system with someone who had been in touch with extraterrestrials and was able to gain some knowledge." This person had made a small UFO prototype and was working on a 50-foot model with financial backing from an Arab country when he died. Cooper had promised visual and photographic material to back the story, but had not yet delivered it. Nevertheless, continued Sherman, "Cooper believes ETs are here.... He also talked about the Center for Advanced Technology. It no longer exists. They were apparently onto some kind of alien technology." If that's not enough, "he also talked about a friend who saw the bodies in Roswell," although Sherman cautioned that "we can't prove these stories."

Cooper's recent revelations seem to follow a pattern of UFO interest displayed throughout his life. He introduced the subject in *We Seven* (1962),

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written by the Mercury astronauts, where he wrote that "I also had the idea that there might be some interesting forms of life out in space for us to discover and get acquainted with. I don't believe in fairy tales, but as far as I am concerned, there have been far too many unexplained examples of unidentified objects sighted around this Earth for us to rule out the possibility that some form of life exists beyond our own world."

Cooper retired from the air force in 1970 as a colonel. As the 1978 UN initiative was taking shape, Cooper dropped a prime time bombshell on the *Merv Griffin* show. "There is a story going around, Gordon, that a spaceship did land somewhere in middle America and there were occupants, and members of our government were able to keep one of the occupants alive... is that a credible story?" asked Griffin. Cooper responded: "I think it's fairly credible. I would like to see the time when all qualified people could really work together

to properly investigate these stories and either refute or prove them."

While Cooper has been outspoken about UFOs, he has not endorsed the accounts of alleged sightings by astronauts in space, including one that he supposedly had during his record-setting 1963 Mercury-9 flight. In his letter to Ambassador Griffith, Cooper wrote that "most astronauts are very reluctant to even discuss UFOs due to the great numbers of people who have indiscriminately sold fake stories and forged documents abusing their names and reputations without hesitation. Those few astronauts who have continued to have a participation in the UFO field have had to do so very cautiously. There are several of us who do believe in UFOs and who have had occasion to see a UFO on the ground, or from an airplane. There was only one occasion from space which may have been a UFO." That probably refers to Jim McDivitt's sighting during the Gemini-4 flight in 1965, but that's another story. ■